

Camila Vega

On the Rag

credits	
creator	Camila Vega
Photos	Finley Banks
writing	Camila Vega
layout design	Finley Banks
medium	Essay

From a young age, I was taught that when I reached puberty, I would begin menstruating, and that this would somehow mark my transition from girlhood into womanhood. As a child, I was delighted by the idea that one day I would grow into a woman capable of accomplishing my goals and dreams. However, reality set in when I got my first period. I experienced pain, vomiting, and tears, staining my bed and clothes, and I could not understand how something so physically unbearable could define me as a “woman” in the eyes of others. Ever since, I have dreaded the arrival of my period, knowing it means struggling to carry out my daily tasks while enduring excruciating pain. However, this pain is not limited to only me; millions of women worldwide endure painful periods with limited or no access to resources that allow them to manage their symptoms or menstruate with dignity. Additionally, the most common products marketed for our menstrual cycles are extremely harmful not only to our bodies but also to the environment. Pads and tampons, though often the most convenient option, take between 500 and 800 years to decompose, and in the United States alone, around 20 billion of these products are discarded each year. So what does it mean to insert or use products that take hundreds of years to decompose so close to such an intimate area? It means that the materials used in many menstrual products are highly carcinogenic and harmful to women’s health over time. And

although more sustainable and body-safe alternatives have been developed in recent years, many women around the world still cannot afford them due to their high cost and the taxes placed on menstrual products, which are often categorized as luxury goods rather than essential health items. As a result, there are countless taboos surrounding menstruation that make it difficult to create better alternatives. These taboos allow corporations to profit from the idea that they can help take away the “shame” of menstruating and turn the experience into a luxury we cannot afford. Therefore, I’ve begun taking matters into my own hands by collaborating with other women to educate and reimagine the systems that continue to control and exploit our bodies without our consent. My goal with this project is to create a book that educates women about the products they use while sparking a conversation about how we can address these issues. I also aim to collaborate with a team of women designers to develop sketches and product designs that offer safer, more affordable, and eco-friendly alternatives. Women should never feel ashamed of their periods, and we must work toward making these alternatives as accessible as possible. Menstrual products should not harm our health or the environment, and no woman should be unable to afford the essential items she needs to manage a completely natural and unavoidable experience.

